

The first tank action

The Mark I, seen here in September 1916, was first used at Flers-Courcelette during the Battle of the Somme. Arguments had raged around when to use the first tanks—wait until there were considerable numbers available to make an overwhelming impact, or use what was ready in the pressing circumstances of the time. The British Commander in Chief, Field Marshal Haig, was eager to see some success on the Somme before the winter set in, and he also knew that attacking could relieve the French forces at Verdun. Haig decided to try out the new tanks and assembled two companies to attack; 49 tanks were ready, although the men barely had time to scout the ground before they went into action.

The tanks were spread along a section of the British line—and they were hardly a success. Only nine made it to or across the German frontline, some fired on their own men, some were hit by the British barrage, and many broke down or ditched. Nevertheless, despite the poor performance overall, there were enough successes by certain tanks to allow Haig to claim that “wherever the tanks advanced we took our objectives, and wherever they did not advance we failed.” He had seen their potential and ordered 1,000 more.

A Mark I tank designated C15 at the battle of Flers-Courcelette, the first ever tank action, on September 15, 1916.

